

Initial Post:

by [Abdulla Husain Salem Hadna Almessabi](#) - Thursday, 30 October 2025, 7:52 AM

Number of replies: 4

Case Study: Automated Active Response Weaponry

The case of the Q Industries indicates, there are severe ethical concerns in the development of autonomous weapon systems. The ACM Code of Ethics (2018) states that a computing professional should not harm people (1.2) and should benefit society and human welfare (1.1). The decision of Q Industries to enable its autonomous systems with lethal abilities is an evident breach of ethics. This kind of technology can be abused and used to invade privacy via facial recognition, thus can threaten innocent lives which is against the human rights and the common good.

The use of autonomous lethal systems is legally questioned because it must be applied in accordance with the international humanitarian law (the Geneva Convention etc), according to which an individual has to be responsible in the war (Docherty, 2020). On the social level, these systems would be a threat to the freedom of speech and protest, undermining the trust of the population (Cath, 2018). The employees who left their jobs and reported about the unethical practices of Q industries did it in line with the Principle 1.7 of the ACM, which advises that professionals report the breach of the law in the best interest of the public.

On the same note, the BCS Code of Conduct (2019) also focuses on the need to act in the public interest, as well as avoid harm caused by computing work. Both codes emphasize on accountability and integrity, which the leadership of Q industries ignored. This case indicates how putting profit or political concerns over ethics undermine professionalism and well-being of the society.

References:

Association for Computing Machinery (ACM) (2018) Case Study: Automated Active Response Weaponry. ACM Code of Ethics and Professional Conduct. Available at: <https://www.acm.org/code-of-ethics/case-studies/automated-active-response-weaponry> (Accessed: 30 October 2025).

Association for Computing Machinery (2018) ACM Code of Ethics and Professional Conduct. Association for Computing Machinery. Available at: <https://www.acm.org/code-of-ethics> (Accessed: 30 October 2025).

British Computer Society (2019) BCS Code of Conduct. British Computer Society. Available at: <https://www.bcs.org/membership/become-a-member/bcs-code-of-conduct/> (Accessed: 30 October 2025)

Cath, C., 2018. Governing artificial intelligence: ethical, legal and technical opportunities and challenges. *Philosophical Transactions of the Royal Society A: Mathematical, Physical and Engineering Sciences*, 376(2133), p.20180080.

Docherty, B.L., 2015. Mind the gap: The lack of accountability for killer robots. Human Rights Watch.